

THE DAILY BRIEF

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MARKETS & FINANCE

Bitcoin, crypto markets, and broader financial news

Bitcoin Just Had Its Biggest Week Ever — in Dollar Terms. Bitcoin recorded its largest weekly dollar gain in history this past week, according to The Block, as the price rallied sharply and trading volume exploded. Combined bitcoin and ether ETF inflows hit \$2.6 billion — the strongest weekly inflow since October and more than triple the prior week's volume. Strive's CEO called it the start of what he expects to be "the strongest cycle ever," pointing to bitcoin's outperformance against both the dollar and gold. (The Block)

Bitcoin and Ether ETFs Are Back in a Serious Way. Those \$2.6 billion in combined ETF inflows came alongside \$29 billion in total weekly trading volume for bitcoin and ether ETF products — more than tripling from the prior week. The catch: both categories are still negative on the year overall, meaning institutional momentum has returned even as earlier buyers remain underwater. If the inflow trend holds, that year-to-date gap closes fast. (The Block)

Strategy Raised \$2 Billion, Bought Zero Bitcoin. In a move that baffled crypto observers, Strategy — the Michael Saylor-led company formerly known as MicroStrategy — sold \$2 billion in MSTR shares last week and then... sat on the cash. The company established a \$1.6 billion "USD Cash" pool rather than deploying into bitcoin, despite holding roughly 4% of bitcoin's entire 21 million supply cap, worth around \$66 billion at current prices. It's the first time in recent memory Strategy has gone quiet on acquisition. (The Block)

Zcash Hit an Eight-Year High Near \$850. The privacy coin surged to levels not seen since 2018, fueled by nearly \$10 billion in 24-hour futures volume and a Grayscale ETF filing pushing sentiment. Open interest hit \$1.76 billion. Whether this is a genuine privacy-use-case rally or another leveraged-driven spike is the question smart money is asking right now. (The Block)

Solana Cut Its Block Time to 350 Milliseconds. Solana shipped its first major network optimization this week, reducing mainnet slot time from higher latency down to 350ms — the first step toward its 200ms target. The change speeds up transaction confirmations but isn't designed to increase overall throughput. It's a quality-of-life upgrade for users and a signal that Solana's engineers are still actively improving the base layer even as the network handles tens of billions in daily volume. (The Block)

DeFi Protocol Term Finance Lost an Estimated \$8.5 Million. Term Finance's lending protocol was exploited via a governance attack, with attackers bypassing a seven-day veto window that was supposed to protect depositors. The hack is a reminder that DeFi's promise of trustless security still depends heavily on smart contract code quality — and that governance mechanisms added as safety features can themselves become attack surfaces. (The Block)

AI & TECH

Artificial intelligence, research breakthroughs, and the companies building the future

A Mysterious AI Model Called Ox Alpha Has the Internet Speculating. A stealth AI model dubbed Ox Alpha appeared seemingly from nowhere and immediately sent certain corners of the internet into a frenzy of speculation — who built it, what it can do, and why it's being kept secret. The model's origin remains unknown, but the chatter suggests something competitive enough that its creators think secrecy is worth more than the marketing lift of an announced launch. (TechCrunch)

OpenAI Says California Should Strengthen Its AI Safety Bill. In a notable reversal, OpenAI publicly called for California to strengthen SB 53, the AI safety bill the company previously opposed. The company is now asking for tougher requirements — a shift that reflects either genuine concern about frontier AI risks or a strategic play to shape the bill's details before it becomes law. Either way, when OpenAI asks for stronger regulations, the political calculus in Sacramento changes. (TechCrunch)

Apple Reportedly Cut Hundreds of Siri and Vision Pro Jobs. Apple's AI ambitions took a quiet hit as the company laid off hundreds of employees across its Siri voice assistant and Vision Pro headset teams, according to multiple reports. The cuts arrive as Apple's AI features have lagged competitors — a painful position for the company that defined the smartphone era with Siri back in 2011. The layoffs suggest Apple is reshuffling its AI org rather than scaling it up. (TechCrunch)

Anthropic's Claude Has a Content Moderation Problem. TechCrunch tested Anthropic's latest Opus 4.6 model and found it relatively easy to bypass content restrictions preventing sexually explicit output. The findings add to a broader conversation about how effectively frontier AI labs can enforce their own safety guidelines — and whether "we tested it internally" is an adequate substitute for real-world red-teaming before deployment. (TechCrunch)

AI Accounting Startup Rillet Raised \$100 Million and Became a Unicorn in 48 Hours. Rillet CEO Nicolas Kopp shared growth metrics at a board meeting and set off a fundraising frenzy from Iconiq, Sequoia, and others — without actively fundraising. In two days, the AI accounting platform went from Series A conversation to unicorn status. The speed reflects how hungry investors are for AI-native enterprise software that touches real business workflows, not just chat interfaces. (TechCrunch)

Nvidia Keeps Investing in the Infrastructure That Invests in Nvidia. Nvidia announced a partnership with data center developer Cloverleaf, continuing its pattern of strategic investments in the physical infrastructure needed to run its own chips. The circular dynamic — Nvidia profits from AI buildout, then deploys those profits to build more data centers that need Nvidia chips — is a self-reinforcing loop that no competitor has found a way to break. (TechCrunch)

Harvard's \$699 AI Startup Bootcamp Uses AI Avatars of Its Instructors. Harvard Business School's Foundry program now offers AI avatars that provide real-time feedback during practice pitches and board meetings. The avatars don't replace instructors — they're practice partners that let founders run through scenarios repeatedly without wearing out the human faculty. At \$699, it's positioned as accessible compared to the full MBA price tag. (TechCrunch)

AI 'Teammates' That Replicate Scientific Research Are Here. Inherent, a British AI lab founded by DeepMind alumni, released Faraday — an AI agent that can replicate scientific research papers. The company claims it outperformed both Anthropic and OpenAI on this task. If reproducible, it represents a meaningful step toward AI systems that can accelerate the pace of science itself, not just describe it. (TechCrunch)

BRIEFLY

- < **Uber was fined nearly \$1 billion (euro 825 million) by Dutch regulators** over automated driver suspension practices that violated Europe's GDPR — the second-largest GDPR penalty on record. (TechCrunch)
- < **China delayed its critical Chang'e 7 Moon mission to 2027**, citing the need for "absolute success" — a notable shift for a program that has maintained a consistent launch cadence. (Ars Technica)
- < **Trump's administration called for a new heavy-lift spaceport on federal land**, acknowledging the current launch infrastructure can't handle the surge in commercial and government missions. (Ars Technica)
- < **Fasset raised \$68 million at a \$1 billion valuation** in a Series C led by SBI Group, becoming the latest stablecoin infrastructure company to hit unicorn status. (The Block)
- < **Bernstein gave Circle a 59% upside target**, arguing the stablecoin issuer can sustain growth even without the Clarity Act passing — USDC supply is already rebounding. (The Block)

THE TAKEAWAY

The most important signal across both markets and tech this week is the same force: institutional money rotating back into crypto at the fastest pace in a year, even as the fundamentals — ETF infrastructure, stablecoin adoption, DeFi lending — keep getting more mature. Bitcoin's record dollar week isn't just a price story; it's a story about what happens when the plumbing works and the narrative aligns. Meanwhile in AI, the Ox Alpha mystery and OpenAI's reversal on safety legislation tell the same story — this industry is moving so fast that the rules are being written in real time, often by the companies that should be most constrained by them.

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